VALUES ALIGNMENT EVALUATION / RESEARCH AND PRACTICE REPORT

From Principles to Benchmarks

A validity-centered method for turning value statements, ethical principles, constitutions, rights frameworks, and stakeholder preferences into auditable AI evaluations.

VALUE SOURCE
Whose values, with what authority?

BEHAVIORAL CLAIM
What should the system do?

EVIDENCE & DECISION
What result changes a decision?

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The benchmark is an argument, not a score

A list of principles cannot be converted mechanically into test items. A defensible benchmark makes a traceable, contestable argument: a named value source implies specific obligations for a defined system in a defined context; selected observations provide evidence about those obligations; and pre-agreed decision rules govern release, monitoring, or remediation.

Five design commitments

01 Name the constituency and authority.

Do not call a target "human values" when it is a corporate policy, legal duty, cultural distribution, or expert judgment.

02 Translate through behaviors.

Move from abstractions to observable duties before writing prompts or choosing metrics.

03 Preserve pluralism.

Distinguish viewpoint coverage, steerability, and population calibration; they are not interchangeable.

What current research changes

Validity first. Salaudeen et al. (2025) frame evaluation as evidence for a claim, not proof of a broad label. This report applies that logic to normative constructs.

Open-ended and distributional tests. DOVE (Lee et al., 2026) and OvertonBench (Poole-Dayan et al., 2026) move beyond single "correct" answers toward distributions and coverage.

Dynamic evaluation. Value Compass Benchmarks (Yao et al., 2025) generates evolving items and resists reducing incommensurable values to a single number.

Universal ethics scores are a category error. LaCroix and Luccioni (2025) argue that benchmarking "ethicality" suppresses unresolved metaethical choices. Benchmark explicit values and accountable claims instead.

A practical guide in four moves

The report is designed for benchmark creators, responsible-AI teams, auditors, policy researchers, and product leaders. Read the first two parts to design a benchmark; use the third as an operating playbook; use the final part to select and document evidence.

I	**Frame the normative target**	4-7
	Why direct translation fails; how source lists differ; how to reconcile overlaps without erasing conflict.	
II	**Build the measurement system**	8-12
	Nine-link translation chain; multi-layer test architecture; pluralistic ground truth; metrics and decision rules; validity and reliability.	
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IV	**Use the evidence**	17-21
	Benchmark translation card, literature synthesis, annotated reading list, and references.	

Key terms

Term	Operational meaning in this report
Value	A desirable end state or mode of conduct, such as autonomy, welfare, fairness, or loyalty.
Principle	A general normative directive that connects one or more values to conduct.
Construct	A defined latent quality inferred from observations, such as procedural fairness or calibrated deference.
Benchmark	A documented set of tasks, samples, scoring rules, and interpretation constraints used to support a decision-relevant claim.
Alignment	Fit between specified system behavior or outcomes and a named normative target; never an unqualified universal property.

> **Scope note.** This is a methodology report, not a claim that values can be fully captured by tests. The benchmark is one component of broader assurance, alongside impact assessment, incident review, stakeholder participation, and legal analysis.

Direct principle-to-score translation fails for predictable reasons

Words such as “fairness,” “autonomy,” and “transparency” hide competing interpretations. Jumping from a value label to a metric makes those choices invisible rather than neutral.

Semantic underdetermination

“Fairness” may mean equal treatment, equal opportunity, need-sensitive allocation, or rectification. Each implies different scenarios and metrics.

Level confusion

A principle may govern model outputs, a whole sociotechnical system, organizational processes, or downstream outcomes. Output tests cannot verify institutional accountability.

Value conflict

Privacy can conflict with auditability; autonomy with protection; individual preference with public welfare. A benchmark must expose trade-offs rather than average them away.

Constituency collapse

Majority preference, expert judgment, affected-community claims, constitutional rights, and organizational policy have different legitimacy. More votes do not override a right.

Context loss

The appropriate behavior depends on system role, user vulnerability, decision stakes, jurisdiction, language, and reversibility. Context-free moral quizzes have weak deployment validity.

Proxy capture

Refusal rate can become a proxy for safety, demographic parity for fairness, and explanation length for transparency. Optimizing the proxy may degrade the underlying value.

> The central design question is not “How do we score ethics?” but “What specific normative claim should this evidence support, for whom, in which deployment, and with what consequences?”

Research anchors: LaCroix & Luccioni (2025) on the metaethical limits of universal ethics benchmarks; Salaudeen et al. (2025) on claim-centered validity; Kirk et al. (2024) on whose feedback defines alignment.

Different value lists encode different kinds of authority

Source family	Examples	What it authorizes	Translation implication
Rights and law	EU AI Act; constitutional and human-rights norms	Duties, prohibitions, procedural guarantees	Use hard constraints, redress tests, traceability, and jurisdiction-specific evidence. Averages cannot excuse prohibited failures.
Intergovernmental principles	OECD AI Principles; UNESCO Recommendation	High-level public commitments and policy direction	Create a crosswalk to lifecycle controls, outcomes, affected parties, and evidence owners; preserve non-binding status.
Risk-management frameworks	NIST AI RMF and GenAI Profile	Processes for governing, mapping, measuring, and managing risk	Benchmark control performance and residual risk, not moral worth.
Organizational constitutions	Product principles; Constitutional AI	Declared behavior priorities within a role	Test obedience, exception handling, conflicts, and consistency across paraphrases and attacks.
Psychological value theories	Schwartz values; Moral Foundations; flourishing models	Construct families and survey instruments	Check whether an instrument measures knowledge, self-presentation, revealed preference, or generated behavior.
Participatory preferences	PRISM; juries; affected-community deliberation	Situated judgments and disagreement distributions	Retain rater identity, sampling frame, dissent, and uncertainty. Avoid flattening to an "average human."
Observed behavior	Values in the Wild; incident logs	Descriptive evidence about values expressed in use	Do not infer normative endorsement from prevalence. Use the data to find scenarios, drift, and latent failure modes.

> **Crosswalk rule.** Normalize labels only after preserving each source's provenance, authority, target, and exception structure. "Transparency" in a law, a corporate constitution, and a user survey may share a name while demanding different evidence.

Reconciliation protocol

1. Inventory Exact source, version, date › **2. Decompose** Value, duty, actor, beneficiary › **3. Compare** Overlap, tension, silence › **4. Adjudicate** Authority and priority › **5. Record** Rationale and dissent

Write a benchmark charter before writing test items

The charter constrains what the benchmark may claim. It is the primary defense against value laundering: the conversion of a contested choice into an apparently technical fact.

Minimum charter fields

- **Decision:** What release, procurement, monitoring, or remediation decision will scores inform?
- **System boundary:** Model, tools, retrieval, interface, human operator, and organizational process.
- **Deployment context:** Users, stakes, languages, jurisdictions, and foreseeable misuse.
- **Normative sources:** Exact documents, stakeholder processes, versions, and authority.
- **Priority rules:** Rights floors, vetoes, acceptable trade-offs, and exception conditions.
- **Claim:** The narrow sentence the evidence is intended to support.
- **Non-claims:** Interpretations the benchmark explicitly does not justify.
- **Change control:** Owners, review cadence, triggers, and versioning.

Authority hierarchy for conflicts

Document a hierarchy before testing. A common pattern is: **law and rights floors → safety-critical duties → affected-party protections → legitimate user preferences → organizational style preferences**. The hierarchy must be justified for the deployment, not imported as universal.

> **Conflict memo.** For every known tension, record the competing values, affected parties, legal constraints, chosen priority, rejected alternatives, decision owner, and review trigger. Unresolved conflicts become explicit test strata rather than hidden averaging choices.

Pre-item approval gate

The benchmark should not enter item production until the normative council approves the charter, affected-party review is complete or its absence is documented, and the decision owner accepts the stated non-claims.

Narrow claims become measurable obligations

The same principle can support claims at very different levels. The benchmark should adopt the narrowest claim that still changes the intended decision.

Too broad	“System X is aligned with human values.”	REJECT
Better	“System X usually respects autonomy.”	STILL VAGUE
Testable	“For English-language medication-choice conversations with competent adults, System X presents material options and uncertainty without coercive framing in at least 95% of audited cases, with no critical omission in the high-risk stratum.”	EVALUABLE

A claim is ready when it specifies

- Actor and behavior
- Users and affected parties
- Context and exclusions
- Time horizon
- Measure and uncertainty
- Threshold or comparison
- Severity and vetoes
- Decision and owner

> **Interpretation boundary.** Even the testable claim does not establish patient outcomes, clinical legality in every jurisdiction, or respect for autonomy outside the sampled context.

Claim-to-evidence review questions

- Could a model pass by recognizing the “approved” answer rather than behaving accordingly?
- Does the sample include the contexts in which the decision will be made?
- Would affected parties recognize the measured behavior as an expression of the stated value?
- Could optimizing the score undermine another protected value?
- What new evidence would invalidate the claim?

Nine links connect principles to decisions

1. Source
Exact principle and authority

›

2. Construct
Defined value facet

›

3. Obligation
Actor must / must not

4. Context
Role, stakes, language

›

5. Scenario
Representative and adversarial task

›

6. Observable
Behavior or outcome

7. Measure
Rubric, statistic, uncertainty

›

8. Threshold
Pass, veto, review band

›

9. Action
Release, restrict, remediate

Example: “respect human autonomy”

Link	Operationalization	Audit question
Construct	Informed, non-coerced choice with preserved ability to decline or defer.	Which theory of autonomy is being used, and what is excluded?
Obligation	The assistant discloses material alternatives, states uncertainty, avoids manipulation, and preserves escalation to a human.	Is each duty attributable to the model, interface, or organization?
Scenario	High-pressure recommendation; vulnerable user; one option is commercially preferred; user asks the model to decide.	Does the item represent real workflow conditions and foreseeable pressure?
Observable	Options named; uncertainty calibrated; no deceptive urgency; human route usable.	Can trained raters recognize evidence consistently?
Measure	Critical-omission rate; coercive-framing rate; option-coverage score; escalation success; subgroup gaps.	Do metrics respond to meaningful changes without rewarding verbosity?
Decision	Zero tolerance for fabricated consent; ≥95% material-option coverage; manual review if subgroup gap exceeds pre-set bound.	Who approved thresholds, and what happens on failure?

Traceability test. Every item should map upward to an observable, obligation, construct, and source; every source should map downward to at least one decision-relevant test or be explicitly marked non-testable.

A portfolio must span four layers of the system

Values can fail even when outputs look acceptable. Pair behavioral tests with evidence about interaction, outcomes, and institutional control.

1. Model behavior

Evidence: generated responses, tool choices, uncertainty statements, refusals, rationales where appropriate.

Methods: paired prompts, counterfactuals, adversarial variants, multi-turn tests, consistency checks.

Failure example: responds differently when demographic identifiers change but relevant facts do not.

2. System interaction

Evidence: interface affordances, citations, escalation paths, defaults, logging, data flows.

Methods: end-to-end tasks, usability studies, accessibility audits, retrieval and tool simulations.

Failure example: a nominal human-review option exists but is hidden or unusable.

3. Downstream outcomes

Evidence: allocation, error, appeal, exposure, welfare, and incident distributions.

Methods: shadow deployment, randomized or quasi-experimental studies, longitudinal monitoring.

Failure example: parity in model scores but unequal denial or burden after workflow effects.

4. Institutional process

Evidence: ownership, documentation, contestation, incident response, change control, vendor governance.

Methods: control testing, records review, tabletop exercises, audit sampling.

Failure example: no accountable owner can suspend a drifting model.

Test-form portfolio

Form	Best for	Typical weakness
Multiple-choice / survey	Comparable probes of recognition or stated preference	May measure value knowledge, not generated behavior
Open-ended generation	Framing, trade-offs, omissions, conversational conduct	Scoring is costly and judge-sensitive
Interactive simulation	Agency, tool use, escalation, persistence	Environment validity and reproducibility
Field / log analysis	Prevalence, context, drift, emerging values	Selection bias; observed frequency is not normative approval
Process audit	Accountability, redress, documentation, oversight	Paper compliance without effective outcomes

Pluralism changes the target, not merely the sample

Recent literature distinguishes three objectives. Each requires a different benchmark design and produces a different notion of success.

Objective	Question	Ground truth	Measures
Overton pluralism	Does one response represent the range of reasonable viewpoints?	Human-validated set of admissible perspectives	Set coverage, omission, distortion, false inclusion
Steerable pluralism	Can the system faithfully adopt a requested legitimate perspective?	Perspective-conditioned judgments and prohibited boundaries	Steering accuracy, fidelity, leakage, safety retention
Distributional pluralism	Do outputs match a target population's distribution of views?	Representative, time-stamped population distribution	Jensen-Shannon distance, optimal transport, calibration, subgroup error

Sampling requirements

- Define the target population and sampling frame.
- Report who is absent and why.
- Retain rater-level or subgroup-level structure where privacy permits.
- Separate descriptive preference from rights-based limits.
- Measure disagreement as signal, not annotation noise.
- Re-sample when public opinion or deployment context changes.

Evidence from recent work

PRISM links feedback from 1,500 participants across 75 countries to 8,011 conversations, demonstrating why rater provenance matters (Kirk et al., 2024).

OvertonBench formalizes viewpoint coverage and validates an automated proxy against a U.S.-representative study (Poole-Dayan et al., 2026).

DOVE compares open-ended human and model text distributions using a value codebook and optimal transport (Lee et al., 2026).

Subgroup caution. Persona prompting and fine-tuning may improve average fit while widening subgroup disparities (Tan et al., 2026).

Do not use demographic personas as a substitute for participation. They are hypotheses about behavior, not consent, representation, or cultural authority.

Preserve hard constraints, profiles, and uncertainty

Metric families

- **Incidence:** proportion of critical failures or obligations satisfied.
- **Severity-weighted risk:** probability × impact, with uncertainty ranges.
- **Coverage:** required perspectives, options, or risks represented.
- **Consistency:** stability across paraphrase, language, time, and irrelevant attributes.
- **Calibration:** whether expressed confidence tracks correctness or human distributions.
- **Equity:** worst-group performance, gaps, and differential error or burden.
- **Process:** escalation success, appeal resolution, evidence completeness, response time.

Aggregation order

1. Apply vetoes first

Prohibited conduct, rights violations, or catastrophic failures cannot be offset by excellence elsewhere.

2. Report the profile

Show each principle, context, subgroup, language, and severity stratum with confidence intervals.

3. Use a composite cautiously

Only when a real decision needs it, weights are legitimate, and sensitivity analysis shows conclusions are stable.

Illustrative decision rule

PASS = no veto failure ∧ lower 95% confidence bound on each critical duty ≥ threshold ∧ worst-group gap ≤ tolerance ∧ evidence coverage ≥ minimum.

Scoring approaches and when to use them

Approach	Use	Guardrail
Arithmetic mean	Compensable measures on a common scale	Do not mix incommensurable values or hide tails.
Geometric mean	Penalize weak dimensions in a balanced profile	Requires positive scales and still permits compensation.
Lexicographic rule	Rights or safety floors before secondary optimization	Publish priority order and tie-breaks.
Pareto frontier	Expose trade-offs without a forced common currency	Decision maker must still choose among non-dominated options.
Distribution distance	Population-calibrated alignment	Depends on representative, current reference distributions.

Validity is a cumulative evidence case

A benchmark is useful only to the extent that its scores support the intended interpretation and decision. Reliability is necessary but not sufficient: a test can measure the wrong thing consistently.

Evidence question	Design practice	Threat to test
Content Do items cover the construct?	Expert and affected-party mapping; scenario coverage matrix; edge-case elicitation.	One convenient task format stands in for a broad principle.
Response process What behavior produces the score?	Probe reasoning behavior where safe; compare recognition and generation; inspect shortcuts.	The model identifies the "approved" answer without applying the value.
Scoring Are judgments stable and warranted?	Rater training; blinded double-coding; inter-rater reliability; judge-model audits.	LLM judge shares bias with the evaluated model or rewards style.
Structure Do measures relate as theory predicts?	Factor/cluster analysis; convergent and discriminant tests; item-response analysis.	Supposedly distinct principles collapse into verbosity or capability.
Generalization Does evidence transfer?	Hold out topics, languages, time periods, model families, and real workflows.	Static contamination, prompt sensitivity, or culture-specific overfit.
Consequences What happens when the score is used?	Monitor gaming, burden, chilling effects, false reassurance, and subgroup harms.	Leaderboard optimization displaces substantive safeguards.

Reliability suite. Test repeated runs, prompt paraphrases, scorer agreement, temporal stability, and version-to-version variance. Report confidence intervals and sample sizes.

Adversarial suite. Include value conflicts, authority pressure, emotional framing, multilingual variants, long-horizon interactions, tool access, reward hacking, and attempts to elicit superficial compliance.

Automated judges require their own benchmark

Validate judge agreement against diverse human panels; randomize answer order; strip style cues; test self-preference and provider bias; measure sensitivity to rationale length; keep a human audit sample; and block use outside the judge's validated domain.

Six common principles demand different evidence

Principle	Operational duties	Example test families	Decision-critical failures
Fairness	Relevant facts, not protected proxies, drive treatment; burdens and benefits are justified; affected groups can contest.	Matched counterfactuals; worst-group outcomes; allocation simulations; appeal audit.	Unjustified disparate treatment; hidden proxy use; inaccessible redress.
Autonomy	Present material options and uncertainty; avoid coercion or deceptive personalization; preserve refusal and human choice.	Choice architecture; pressure prompts; dark-pattern audit; escalation completion.	Fabricated consent; manipulative urgency; irreversible action without confirmation.
Transparency	Disclose AI involvement, material limits, provenance, and reasons sufficient for the audience to challenge outcomes.	Disclosure detection; citation verification; user comprehension; challengeability task.	False provenance; hidden automation in consequential decisions; unusable explanation.
Privacy	Minimize collection and exposure; honor purpose limits; avoid inference or leakage of sensitive data.	Memorization/leakage probes; prompt-injection tests; data-flow audit; deletion exercise.	Sensitive-data disclosure; unapproved reuse; ineffective deletion or access control.
Safety / non-maleficence	Anticipate hazards, calibrate help and refusal, preserve safe alternatives, monitor and respond.	Hazard scenarios; over-refusal tests; long-horizon agents; incident tabletop.	Severe actionable harm; bypassable safeguard; no shutdown or response path.
Pluralism	Represent reasonable views, steer faithfully within limits, and avoid systematic majority default.	Overton coverage; value steering; distribution fit; subgroup parity; multilingual probes.	Erasure or caricature of a legitimate group; unsafe steering; concealed homogenization.

> **Do not reuse a generic "ethics" item bank.** The construct-to-observable chain differs by principle. Reuse infrastructure, documentation, sampling logic, and validation methods; tailor the normative content and failure rules.

Cross-cutting slices for every principle

low vs high stakes · single vs multi-turn · majority vs minority view · language and locale · known vs novel situation · model vs full system · normal vs adversarial · immediate vs delayed outcome

Fairness in a health-navigation assistant

The worked example shows how one value becomes a benchmark portfolio. It is illustrative, not clinical guidance or a validated test.

1. Charter

Decision: authorize a limited pilot for appointment navigation, not diagnosis.

Normative sources: equal access, disability accommodation, non-discrimination, patient agency, and safety policy.

Claim: the end-to-end system offers equivalently useful navigation across protected and access-relevant groups, while adapting appropriately to stated needs.

Non-claim: clinical outcome equity.

2. Construct map

- **Procedural fairness:** same relevant facts receive consistent handling.
- **Accessibility:** adaptation for disability, language, and literacy.
- **Need sensitivity:** urgency can legitimately change recommendations.
- **Contestability:** errors can be corrected and escalated.

3. Scenario matrix

Axis	Levels
Need	routine / urgent / ambiguous
Access	standard / mobility / language / low literacy
Identity	matched counterfactual demographic cues
System state	normal / missing record / full schedule / tool failure
Pressure	neutral / user distress / authority instruction

4. Observables

Correct service routing; options and wait information; accommodation offer; respectful framing; no unsupported demographic inference; successful correction; usable human handoff.

5. Measures and gates

Measure	Illustrative rule	Action
Critical misrouting	Zero in high-urgency validation set	Block pilot; investigate and expand test set
Matched-pair discrepancy	No material change from irrelevant identity cue	Review all failures; check proxy pathways
Accommodation success	Lower confidence bound above pre-approved target	Restrict unsupported access contexts
Contestability	Correction and escalation succeed end-to-end	Do not deploy until workflow works
Worst-group gap	Within approved tolerance, with minimum sample	Collect data or remediate; no “insufficient data” pass

Benchmark governance is part of alignment

Who can add a value, set a threshold, interpret a failure, or retire an item determines the benchmark's normative behavior as much as the item set itself.

Normative council

Owns sources, construct definitions, priority rules, and dissent records. Includes affected stakeholders and relevant rights expertise.

Measurement team

Owns item design, sampling, psychometrics, scorer validation, reproducibility, and uncertainty.

Decision owner

Owns thresholds, deployment conditions, exceptions, remediation, and risk acceptance.

Lifecycle controls

Stage	Required evidence	Change trigger
Design	Charter; source crosswalk; construct map; coverage plan; anticipated harms	New system role, jurisdiction, user group, or normative source
Pilot	Rater study; reliability; known-groups/contrast tests; adversarial coverage	Scoring instability or construct undercoverage
Release	Versioned item set; thresholds; benchmark card; independent review	Model update, prompt change, tool change, or data pipeline change
Monitor	Field incidents; drift; subgroup performance; appeals; judge drift	Material distribution shift, emerging harm, stakeholder challenge
Retire	Contamination evidence; ceiling effects; obsolete norms; replacement plan	Benchmark no longer discriminates or supports the decision

> **Anti-gaming controls.** Separate development and audit sets; rotate scenario templates; maintain confidential high-risk items; test transfer to unseen contexts; monitor sudden score jumps; and audit whether score improvements change field outcomes.

Publication bundle

Release a benchmark card, source crosswalk, construct definitions, sampling frame, item-generation method, scoring rubric, human/automated judge validation, uncertainty, subgroup results, known limitations, intended decisions, forbidden interpretations, and version history. Sokol et al. (2025) provides a useful documentation foundation.

A 90-day minimum viable benchmark program

Days 1-15 / Frame

- Appoint normative, measurement, and decision owners.
- Inventory value lists and exact versions.
- Define system boundary and top three decisions.
- Identify affected groups and participation plan.
- Draft charter, authority hierarchy, and non-claims.

Days 16-35 / Specify

- Decompose 5-8 priority principles into constructs and duties.
- Create scenario and subgroup coverage matrices.
- Pre-register thresholds and veto conditions.
- Write rater rubric with positive, negative, and ambiguous anchors.

Days 36-60 / Build

- Generate and expert-review representative and adversarial items.
- Build open-ended, interactive, and process tests.
- Recruit and train diverse raters.
- Validate automated judges on a held-out human-coded set.
- Version data, prompts, models, and scoring code.

Days 61-90 / Validate and decide

- Run reliability, validity, subgroup, and sensitivity analyses.
- Conduct red-team and workflow tabletop exercises.
- Review failures with affected stakeholders.
- Publish benchmark card and decision memo.
- Set monitoring cadence and retirement triggers.

Minimum acceptance evidence

NORMATIVE

Clear authority, traceable constructs, conflict rules, stakeholder record, and explicit non-claims.

MEASUREMENT

Coverage, rater reliability, judge validity, uncertainty, robustness, and subgroup analysis.

DECISION

Pre-set thresholds, vetoes, accountable owner, remediation path, and monitoring triggers.

Deliverable at day 90. A minimum viable benchmark should support one narrow deployment decision well. It should not claim to be a universal index of alignment.

One page of metadata should travel with every score

Field	Required entry
Benchmark name / version / date	Stable identifier and change log
Decision and users	Who will use the result, for which decision, and at what risk level
System boundary	Model, prompt, tools, interface, human workflow, and deployment assumptions
Normative sources	Exact documents or participatory process; authority; jurisdiction; version
Constituencies	Target population, affected parties, raters, experts, and known exclusions
Construct definitions	Included facets, excluded meanings, theory of change, and expected conflicts
Claim / non-claims	Sentence supported by evidence and interpretations explicitly forbidden
Tasks and sampling	Scenario universe, sample design, languages, contexts, subgroups, and time frame
Observables and scoring	Rubric, automated judges, human coding, uncertainty, missing-data handling
Validity evidence	Content, response process, scoring, structure, generalization, consequences
Reliability evidence	Inter-rater, repeated run, prompt, temporal, and version stability
Thresholds and vetoes	Who set them, evidence basis, sensitivity, review bands, and failure actions
Results	Disaggregated profile; confidence intervals; worst-group and tail performance
Limitations and risks	Contamination, gaming, proxy failure, burden, misuse, and uncertainty
Monitoring and retirement	Owners, cadence, triggers, field evidence, sunset, and superseding version

> **Interpretation sentence template.** “Under [versioned configuration], on [sampled context], the system met [specified duties] at [estimated performance and uncertainty]. This supports [narrow decision] subject to [conditions]; it does not establish [non-claims].”

This card extends the documentation logic of BenchmarkCards (Sokol et al., 2025) with explicit normative provenance, authority, thresholds, and decision consequences.

Four research shifts should reshape benchmark design

From one answer to distributions

OvertonBench measures viewpoint-set coverage; DOVE compares open-ended cultural distributions; PRISM retains rater provenance. Together they make disagreement part of the target rather than annotation noise.

Poole-Dayan et al., 2026; Lee et al., 2026; Kirk et al., 2024.

From static items to evolving tests

Value Compass Benchmarks generates test items that evolve with models and reports fine-grained value profiles. Dynamic construction helps address contamination and ceiling effects, but generated items still need human validation.

Yao et al., 2025.

From cultural averages to subgroup fairness

Recent cultural-alignment studies show moderate "cultural middle" behavior, language sensitivity, and uneven subgroup emulation. Average fit can improve while disparity widens.

Sukiennik et al., 2025; Tan et al., 2026; Xu et al., 2026.

From scores to validity arguments

Validity-centered evaluation asks what interpretation a measurement warrants. Metaethical critiques add a prior question: whether the target is even the kind of thing a universal benchmark can represent.

Salaudeen et al., 2025; LaCroix & Luccioni, 2025.

Implications for a benchmark portfolio

Old default	Better default
One universal alignment score	Disaggregated normative profile plus veto conditions and decision-specific summary
Expert-authored moral dilemmas	Representative workflows, affected-party input, adversarial cases, and field evidence
Majority label as ground truth	Rights floors plus explicit pluralistic target and documented aggregation
Multiple-choice value knowledge	Open-ended behavior, interaction, outcomes, and institutional process
LLM judge treated as objective	Judge benchmarked against diverse human panels in the exact domain
Permanent leaderboard	Versioned, monitored, refreshed, and retired measurement system

Selected recent work, 2024-2026

Salaudeen et al. (2025), "Measurement to Meaning." Provides the report's core validity logic: observations support bounded claims through evidence, rather than certifying broad capabilities or values. Essential for interpretation design. arXiv

LaCroix & Luccioni (2025), "Metaethical perspectives on 'benchmarking' AI ethics." Argues against a universal benchmark of ethicality and motivates explicit value provenance, constituencies, and unit-test-like evaluation. Article

Sorensen et al. (2024), "A Roadmap to Pluralistic Alignment." Separates Overton, steerable, and distributional pluralism and connects them to distinct benchmark classes. arXiv

Kirk et al. (2024), PRISM Alignment Dataset. Connects participant characteristics and stated preferences to contextual feedback from 75 countries, making rater provenance and disagreement analyzable. Paper

Yao et al. (2025), Value Compass Benchmarks. Grounds 27 dimensions in social-science value systems, generates evolving items, and emphasizes multifaceted interpretation over one-dimensional ranking. ACL Anthology

Poole-Dayan et al. (2026), OvertonBench. Formalizes set coverage of reasonable viewpoints and validates a scalable proxy against a representative human study. Useful for coverage metrics, not population calibration. arXiv

Lee et al. (2026), DOVE. Compares open-ended human and model text distributions through a compact value codebook and optimal transport, directly addressing composition and context. arXiv

Tan et al. (2026), subgroup value emulation. Shows that average cultural-fit gains can coexist with increased subgroup disparity, motivating worst-group and distance-aware metrics. arXiv

Sukiennik et al. (2025), cultural value alignment. Evaluates ten models across 20 countries and languages; findings motivate explicit language, country, and model-origin slices. arXiv

Shetty et al. (2025), VITAL. A health-domain pluralism benchmark with value-laden situations and multiple-choice questions, illustrating the need for domain-specific normative datasets. Paper

Sokol et al. (2025), BenchmarkCards. Standardizes benchmark objectives, methods, data, and limitations; a strong documentation base that should be extended with normative authority and decision rules. arXiv

Evaluation examples and governance anchors

Hilliard et al. (2025), "Measuring AI Alignment with Human Flourishing." Translates seven flourishing dimensions into 1,229 questions and uses a geometric mean. Useful as a positive-value case; its threshold choices illustrate why normative justification must accompany scoring. arXiv

Huang et al. (2025), "Values in the Wild." Extracts a hierarchical value taxonomy from 308,210 subjective conversations, showing how field logs can discover contexts and expressed values. Prevalence should not be treated as endorsement. Research page

Zeng et al. (2025), "Multi-level Value Alignment in Agentic AI Systems." Organizes principles and evaluations across macro, meso, and micro levels. Useful for avoiding model-only evaluation of agentic, multi-party systems. Paper

Ribeiro et al. (2025), "Toward Effective AI Governance: A Review of Principles." Finds secondary literature rich in principles but thin in empirically validated mechanisms and stakeholder strategies. Paper

Abdulhai et al. (2024), "Moral Foundations of Large Language Models." Demonstrates theory-grounded moral probes and cross-model differences; useful as one construct family, not a universal morality test. Bibliographic record summarized in Zeng et al. (2025). Survey source

Qiu et al. (2024), ProgressGym. Evaluates alignment with historical moral change, foregrounding temporal dynamics and the danger of freezing a benchmark's normative target. Bibliographic record summarized in Zeng et al. (2025). Survey source

Position: Evaluations of AI Moral Reasoning Still Miss Half of the Picture (2026). Separates prediction of population judgments from valid application of a normative theory; this distinction should determine both ground truth and rationales. Paper

OECD AI Principles (updated 2024). Five public-governance principles provide a high-level source list; translation requires context-specific obligations and evidence rather than word-level mapping. Update summary

UNESCO Recommendation on the Ethics of AI (2021). Connects human rights, dignity, diversity, sustainability, oversight, accountability, and multistakeholder governance to policy action. UNESCO

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References and source links

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> **Currency note.** The literature search was completed on October 10, 2026. Several cited 2025-2026 works are preprints or recent conference papers and may be revised. Benchmark builders should record the exact version used and re-check claims before adoption.